CIVIC INTERPLAY

Place-based civic agency with digital and AI methods

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RMIT University, Centre for Urban Research

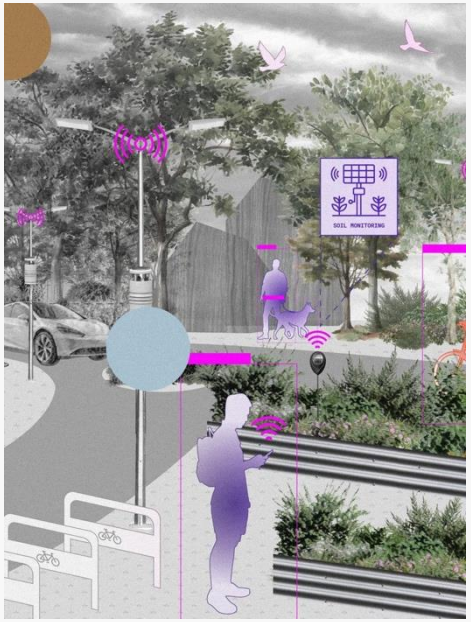
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There is more information about our places than ever before

More of our places, and the infrastructures and services that shape them, are being built through the *intelligence* borne of digital and AI ecosystems.

But who gets to make sense of this?
And who gets to act on it?



An era of escalating anxieties

In an era of AI, advanced digital infrastructure risks losing its social licence to operate. But without strong and resilient digital infrastructure, everyone loses.

This makes the problem of AI governance less of a specialist field and more of *a local issue.*

Frameworks for AI governance need expand, to move beyond specialist technology policy and industry policy.

Communities are demanding greater transparency around the design and governance of the digital infrastructures shaping their everyday lives.

So how can this work?

> "Public input in governmental decision-making is particularly crucial to promoting a well-functioning democracy and mitigating harms from AI. However, *AI's opacity, mutability, and resource requirements* ***impede meaningful civic engagement*** *particularly in urban environments."*

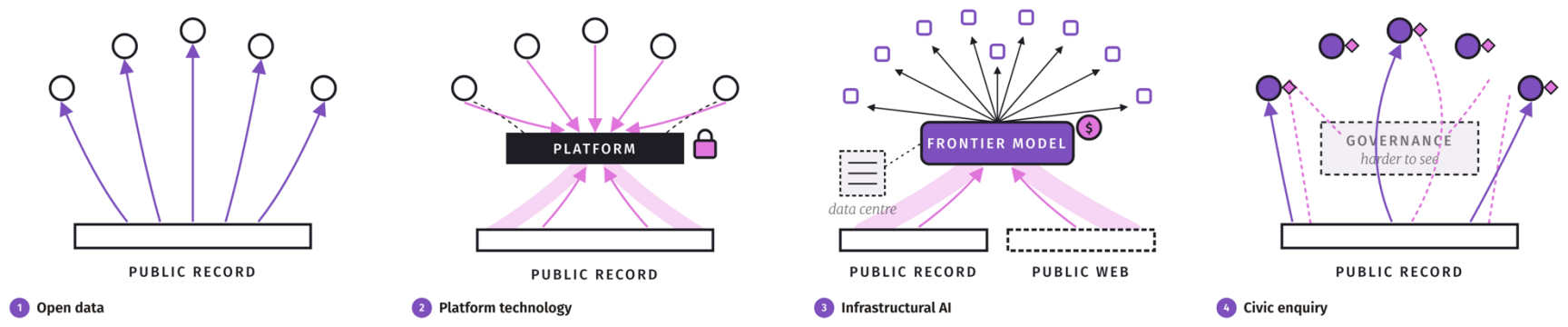
Sieber, R., Brandusescu, A., Sangiambut, S., & Adu-Daako, A. (2025). What is civic participation in artificial intelligence? *Environment and Planning B: Urban Analytics and City Science*, 52(6), 1388-1406. https://doi.org/10.1177/23998083241296200

Information is abundant.
Legibility is unevenly distributed.

From open data to civic enquiry

Open data → platform technology → infrastructural AI → civic enquiry

Timelines are approximate



2008–2013

Open data was promoted to enhance transparency and legibility to support greater participation and accountability.

2013–2018

Platforms built on open data to create more closed or proprietary digital ecosystems, governing access and use through algorithms and paywalls.

2018– onwards

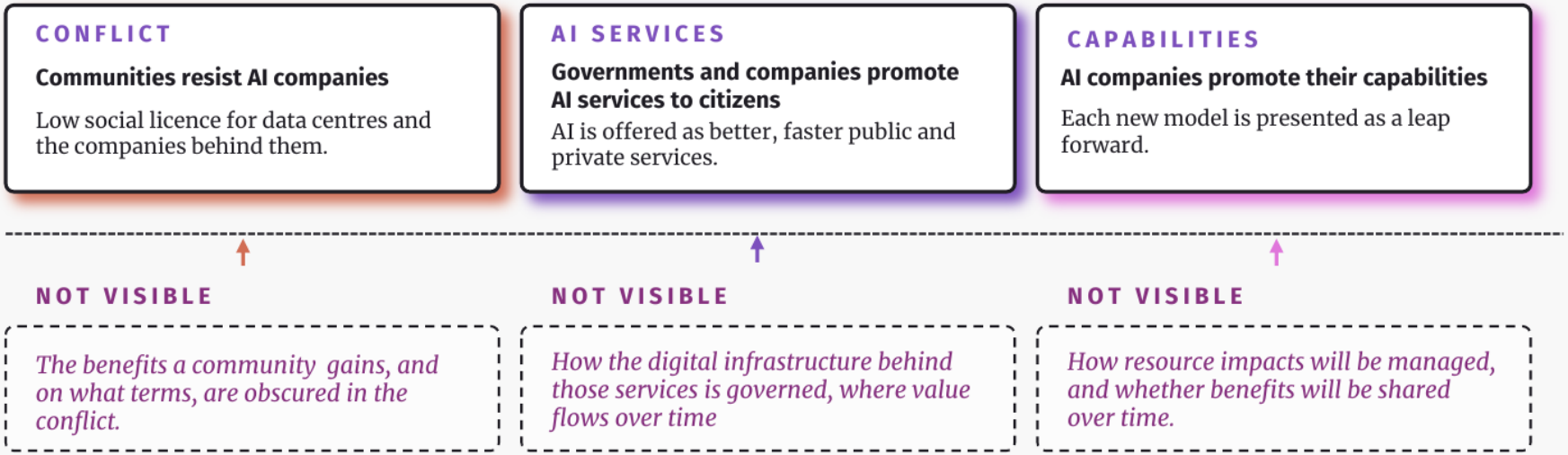
Frontier AI models absorbed public and open (as well as proprietary) data at scale.
Infrastructural AI begins to compete directly with communities

2020s

Citizens enlist AI agents in practices of civic enquiry, seeking shared benefits and accountabilities from digital infrastructure.

Why transparency and legibility

Poor levels of transparency and legibility in the governance of digital services and systems is bad for democratic resilience.



Why transparency and legibility

Benefit claims
What a community could secure, and on what terms, when a data centre or AI Factory lands

Infrastructure governance
how the systems behind AI services are run, what accountabilities are expected

Public trust
Understanding trade offs in investment pathways to promote place based community resilience and prosperity

THE WHY

Transparency in the governance of digital & AI infrastructure is becoming essential to realising its benefits

This is needed so that communities, governments and companies can understand where the benefits lie, and what is actually at stake, before conflict and distrust sets in.

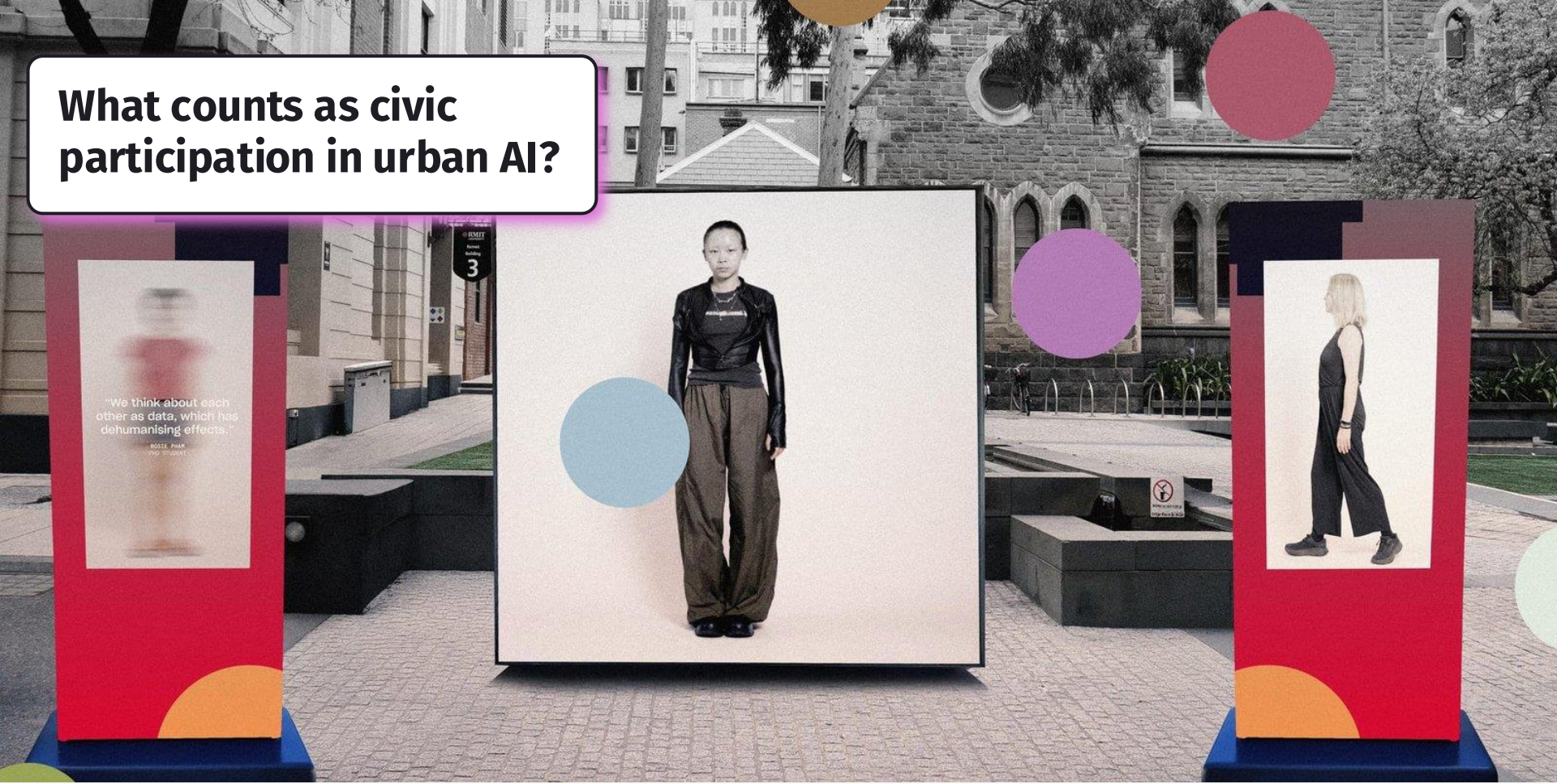
Towards civic agencies?

Civic Interplay explores what practices and forums might promote more meaningful engagement in the conditions shaping digital infrastructure, and how these produce benefits in communities and urban settings. It asks:

What forms of civic enquiry are possible in an era of AI infrastructure?

When digital infrastructure shapes the material and ecological logics of places more explicitly, what forms of democratic accountability do communities expect, and what are they able to access?

What counts as civic participation in urban AI?



What counts as civic participation in urban AI?

AI as the reason to participate
e.g. a police force adopting facial recognition

AI as the medium of participation
e.g. chatbots recommending public services

What gets in the way: AI's opacity, its mutability, and the resources it takes.

STRONGEST FORM

Able to investigate, contest, influence or dismantle AI systems

Partners in design and decisions

Informed and consulted

Citizens as customers or users

Sieber, Brandusescu, Sangiambut and Adu-Daako (2025), Environment and Planning B 52(6).
Ladder after Arnstein (1969).

Civic AI in Liverpool: data as a civic asset

Evidence gathered close to the people affected → **Shared infrastructure, governed by accountable institutions** → **Turned into public good**

THE INSTITUTIONS

Civic Data Cooperative

The UK's first, from 2019. Funded by the Combined Authority, hosted at the University of Liverpool.

Civic Health Innovation Labs

The University, the NHS, local government and industry, working on shared challenges.

Community Charter on Data and AI

Shaped in 2025 with residents of all six boroughs. First principle: data and AI must benefit the community.

The test: do inequalities narrow?

A lineage from Dr William Henry Duncan, Liverpool's first Medical Officer of Health, who used data on disease and housing in the 1840s.

Taiwan: deliberation at scale, with AI in the loop

vTAIWAN

Opinion
Facts and evidence crowdsourced, over about a month

→

Reflection
Pol.is maps agreement and disagreement towards rough consensus

→

Face to face
A live-streamed meeting with key stakeholders

→

Recommendations
Taken to government, as with ride-sharing rules

ALIGNMENT ASSEMBLY ON INFORMATION INTEGRITY

100,000+ invitations
Sent at random through the government SMS hotline

→

450 people
Chosen by stratified sampling

→

Groups of 10
Six hours online, with AI-assisted facilitation

→

Shared position
e.g. AI-generated content should carry provenance marks

Community benefit deals around data centres

WORKED EXAMPLE · LANCASTER, PENNSYLVANIA, 2025

Funds
$10M economic development fund (community foundation) and $10M clean energy fund (city)

Limits
Water capped at 20,000 gallons a day per campus; noise tied to existing levels

Energy
100% clean energy, with penalties up to $10M a building, though critics call the wording soft

Transparency
Full public records access

OTHER MODELS

Memphis
25% of data centre property tax funds projects within five miles

Cedar Rapids
A Community Betterment Fund, tied to jobs and investment targets

HIDDEN

Few deals are public. One review found only eight in the US; non-disclosure agreements keep others from view.

PRACTICES OF CIVIC AI · RADICLE CIVICS, KOREA

Participating in the protocols of space

PERMISSIONING THE CITY · WITH DAEGU, SOUTH KOREA

Find a space
Underused urban spaces made discoverable

→

Write the rules
Communities make and adjust rules together, from templates

→

Decide together
An "explained vote" supports inclusive decisions

→

AI-supported permissions
Next version: AI facilitates, peers still decide

RADICLE CIVICS · THREE SHIFTS

From objects **to agents**

From externalities **to entanglements**

From public–private **to commoning**

Rivers, land and homes treated as agents in a web of care, tested through "proofs of possibility" such as #FreeHouse and #FreeRiver.

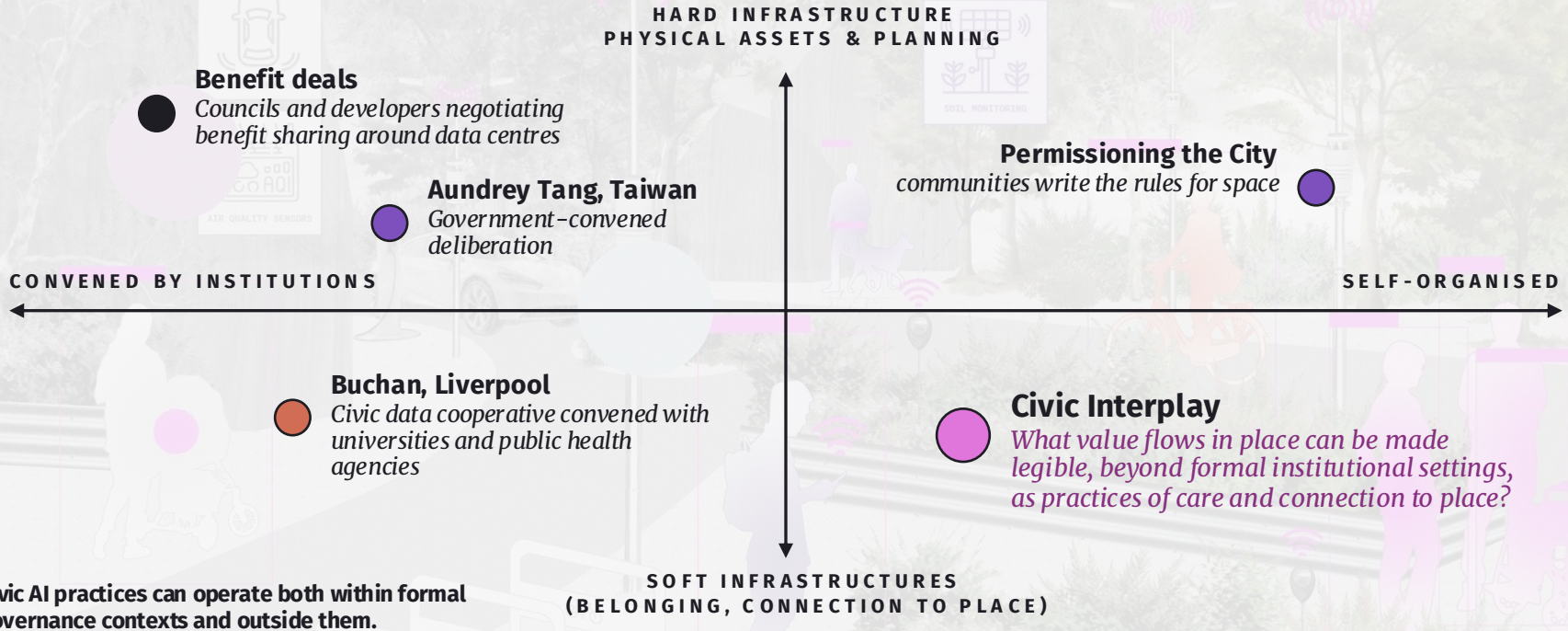
Where Civic Interplay sits

THE PRACTICE	FOCUS AREA	WHAT CIVIC INTERPLAY BUILDS ON
Sieber et al.	A framework for what counts as meaningful participation	**A practice anyone can run, with AI as both the subject and the tool of enquiry**
Buchan, Liverpool	A place-based institutional sponsor for data as a civic asset	**Keeps place, not data, at the centre of AI governance and data licenses**
Tang, Taiwan	A process: deliberation at scale	**Methods of enquiry outside formal governance contexts: more attention to place flows than policy deliberation**
Benefit deals	A contract: negotiated terms	**Conditions of legibility and traceability over time – beyond one-off negotiations**
Dark Matter Labs	A protocol: the rules for how space is used	**The history of permissions, so new protocols can learn from what past ones did to a place**

A relational method, for anyone to adopt: what would happen if you could trace and build different relations with your place?

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Mapping the terrain



Civic AI practices can operate both within formal governance contexts and outside them. Does meaningful engagement depend on institutional acknowledgement?

Practising Civic Interplay

Taking a deliberately experimental stance, civic interplay is inspired by everyday practices of *care-full* placemaking & participation.

As a practice, it seeks locations where digital architectures, sense-making and civic participation can be examined in more collaborative ways.

Questions:

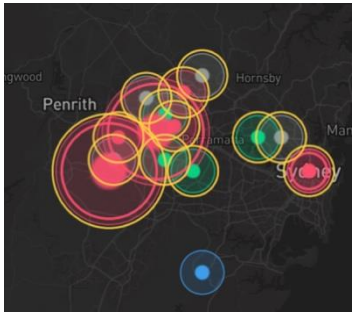
- How are places assembled as digital objects and governance ecosystems
- What forms of accountability and legibility do these systems foster.
- What kinds of exclusions are evidenced?

THE INTENTION

Cultivating greater awareness of the institutional contexts shaping how places are known and become legible, and doing so from multiple vantage points: *sensory, digital and agentic ways of seeing.*

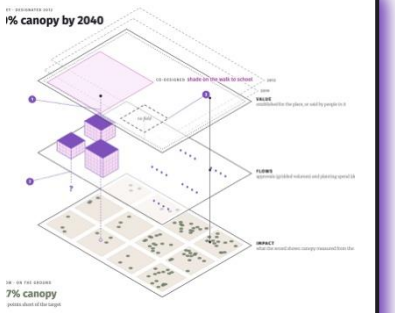
PROJECTS

Current practices



SHARED RECORDS · LIVE

Data Centres Transparency Project (Australian view)



EXPERIMENTAL

Tracing public value in place: Mapping investment flows



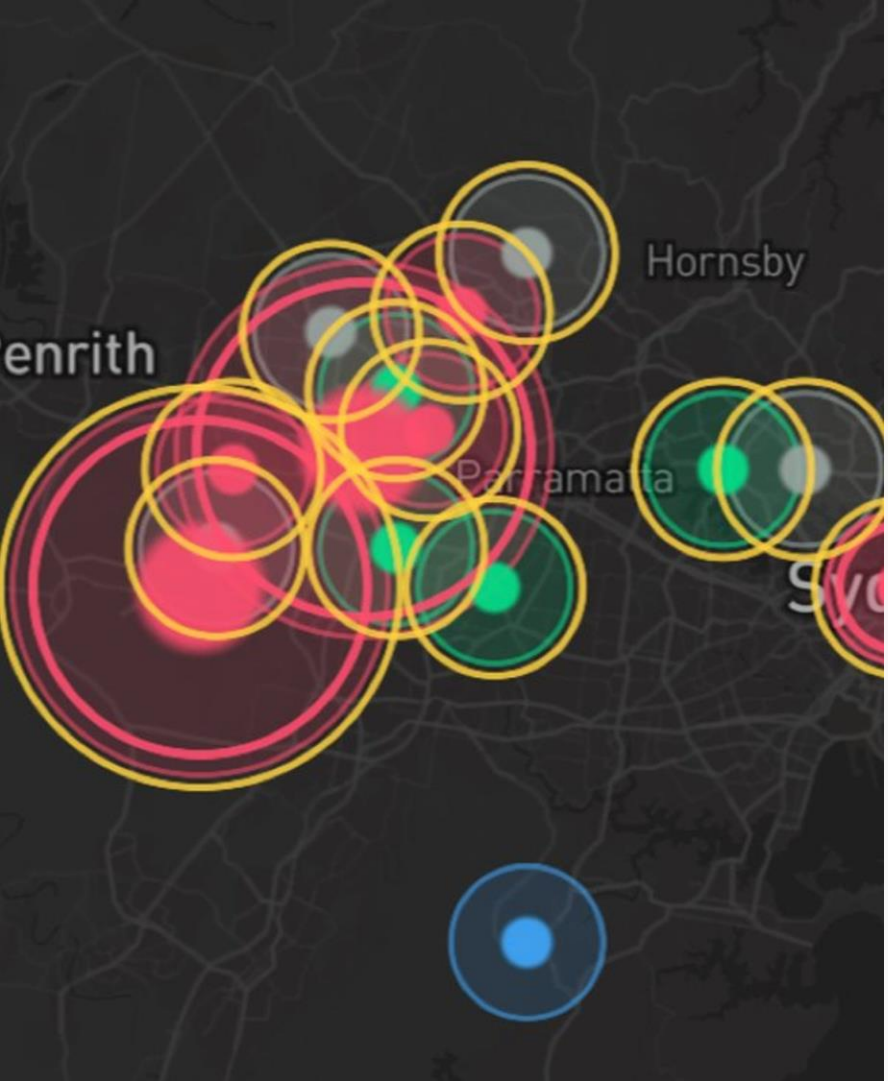
EXPERIMENTAL METHOD

Gathering Intelligences: Field Studies



PLACE

We Care & Ambient Commons for City North Innovation Precinct



SHARED RECORDS · LIVE

Data Centres Transparency Project

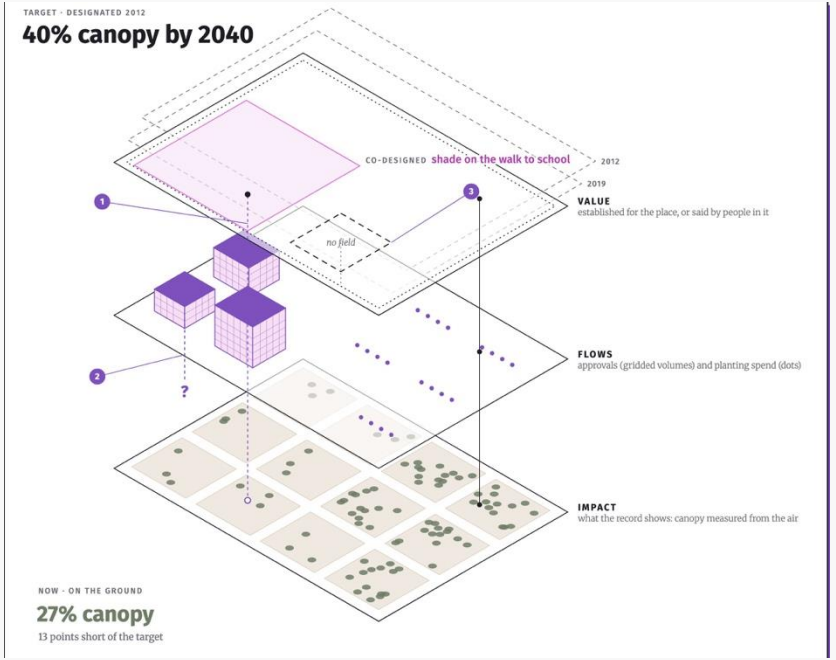
A live map of the data centre build-out in Australia. Site by site: who owns the compute, what it draws in power and water, how it was approved, and what has been disclosed since.

Records and method published openly, with a DOI. The evidence base for the Senate submission on AI and data centres.

Tracing public value: *A side angle on a place*

An exploded axonometric view of a place, built from its public registers of investment and set against named priorities and targets.

VALUE	What was promised, or said by people in the place
FLOWS	Where money and approvals went
IMPACT	What the public record shows happened



Speculative; figures illustrative.

EXPERIMENTAL METHOD

Gathering Intelligences

An experimental walking practice, assembling the digital and sensory conditions that shape attention to practices of care and connection in everyday spaces.

1

Assemble the records

Gather the public record of a project or precinct, through time.

2

Begin your dig

What was the core priority for your place twenty years ago? Or ten?

3

Making sense

A map, a diagram, or a chart? Which values are most evident?

4

Sense checking

Walk your place, add your sightings, and bring it back.

Agent skills for Claude, ChatGPT, Gemini or your own model, with prompts for each step.



PLACE · RMIT CITY NORTH

WeCare

Participatory storytelling for RMIT's City North Social Innovation Precinct, opening its idea of a ‘platform for common growth’ to many voices.

Stories of the future written together, through the lens of care and common growth

A silent walk through the precinct, noticing together

A co-intelligent partner an AI version of the shared conversation, to test how it felt,

Portraits from the day were shown on STORYBOX during the City North Activation program, October to November 2025.

Collaboration

Become a site for civic enquiry

Collaborate on the following activities:

- *A place read: A side angle on a place: how investment flows have impacted place experience and value*
- *A field study or walk: Walk and assemble with others to build a novel digital architecture of place.*
- *A benefits register: Mapping flows of value at contested sites (e.g.) data centres towards a shared benefits register*
- *Other ideas?*

PARTNER TYPOLOGIES

- **Innovation precincts (multipartner governance)**
- **Placemaking Professionals**
- **Policy Researchers**
- **Sustainability Managers & Data Strategists**
- **Community Engagement Strategists**
- **Curious citizens**

Learn more

Civic Interplay is a practice-led program led by Dr Sarah Barns and collaborators, through a Vice-Chancellor's Senior Research Fellowship at RMIT University's Centre for Urban Research.

Friends and collaborators include the Futures + Literacies + Methods Lab at Utrecht University, Irina Panovich (aiio studio), Amber Theurer (HUMAN AF) and Miguel McCormick (Facta Living Lab, Mexico).

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